10 STATUS UPDATES YOUR MANAGER ACTUALLY TRUSTS

Say It Like They Hear It

Dennis · Sr PM at Microsoft · @dennisthinks_

1 When you need an answer

Don’t say: “Just checking in on this.”

> INSTEAD SAY
> **“Still need the API estimate. Blocked without it. Can you send it by Friday?”**

What he hears: “This can wait.” He answers because you named a date.

2 When you don’t know yet

Don’t say: “I don’t know.”

> INSTEAD SAY
> **“I’ll have that by 2.”**

What he hears: “He is stalling.” He hears a plan when you name a time.

3 When someone else blocks you

Don’t say: “I’m still waiting on them.”

> INSTEAD SAY
> **“I’ve asked twice. I need you to unblock it.”**

What he hears: “He complains. He does not push.” It names the block and hands him the fix.

4 When you need a review

Don’t say: “Can you take a look when you get a chance?”

> INSTEAD SAY
> **“I need this Thursday. Does that work?”**

What he hears: “No rush at all.” Dates get answers. ‘When you can’ gets forgotten.

5 When you inherit a project

Don’t say: “I inherited this mess.”

> INSTEAD SAY
> **“Here’s where it was. Here’s where it is now.”**

What he hears: “He blames the last person.” He hears ownership when you show progress.

6 When you’re running late

Don’t say: “We’re a bit behind.”

> INSTEAD SAY
> **“We slip 4 days. New date is the 18th. Nothing else moves.”**

What he hears: “He hides slips until they explode.” He can plan around 4 days and a date. “A bit behind” gives him nothing to plan with.

7 Bad news for leadership

Don’t say: “There’s a small issue with the launch.”

> INSTEAD SAY
> **“Launch is at risk. Two of 5 regions are not ready. I need a call today.”**

What he hears: “He shrinks bad news.” Call it at risk. Name what is missing. Then ask for the call. Small words make him dig, and digging reads as hiding.

8 Escalating

Don’t say: “Legal still hasn’t responded. It’s been weeks.”

> INSTEAD SAY
> **“Legal has had it 12 days. I need it raised today, or the date moves.”**

What he hears: “He complains about people, not time.” Say 12 days and he can act on it. Say “weeks” and he hears a complaint. A number gives him something to raise in the room.

9 Giving a red status

Don’t say: “Status is red. We’re working on it.”

> INSTEAD SAY
>
> **“Red. Cause is the vendor delay. Fix lands Thursday. Next update Friday, 9am.”**

What he hears: “Red means panic.” Give him the cause, the fix, and when the next update lands. Then he can repeat your red upstairs without guessing.

10 Following up a second time

Don’t say: “Sorry, just bumping this again.”

> INSTEAD SAY
>
> **“Second follow-up. I need this by 3 today, or I escalate.”**

What he hears: “He asks nicely and waits.” Drop the sorry. Sorry says you expect to be ignored. A time and a next step say you won’t be.

Practice on this one

Rewrite last week’s update with these swaps. Read it out loud. If it sounds like an apology, do it again.

Score every update

- [ ] Did I name a date, not a feeling?
- [ ] Did I ask for one clear thing?
- [ ] Did I name the block and the fix?
- [ ] Did I count the days, not say “a while”?
- [ ] Did I show progress, not blame?